THE PERSIAN WARS

THE FIRST OF THE WARS between the Greek city-states and Persia was provoked by the Ionian revolt in 499 BCE, a rebellion of the Greek cities of Asia Minor, which were under Persian rule. After suppressing this revolt, the Persians embarked on two unsuccessful invasions of Greece itself. The Persian fleets were initially superior at sea, but by 480, under the inspired leadership of Themistocles, Athens had built a formidable force of triremes. This enabled the Greek allies to crush the invaders at Salamis. The Greeks then took the offensive, using their sea power to carry out operations in Asia Minor, Cyprus, and Egypt.



THE PERSIAN WARS c.499–448 BCE

The Persian Empire, founded by Cyrus the Great in the 6th century BCE, expanded westward into the Middle East, Egypt, and Asia Minor, rapidly becoming the dominant power in the eastern Mediterranean. Under Cyrus's successor Darius, it even extended into Europe. The revolt of the Greek city-states on the Aegean coast of Asia Minor led to the invasions of Greece mounted by Darius (492 BCE) and his son Xerxes (480 BCE).

KEY

- Persian Empire and vassals c.500 BCE
- Greek opponents of Persia
- Route of Xerxes' army 480 BCE
- Route of Xerxes' fleet 480 BCE
- Greek victory
- Persian victory
- Inconclusive battle

GRECO–PERSIAN WARS

LADE



Date 494 BCE
Forces Persian fleet (mainly Phoenicians): 600 ships; Greeks: 353 triremes
Losses Persians: 57 ships; Greeks: 234 triremes

Location Off Miletus, western Turkey

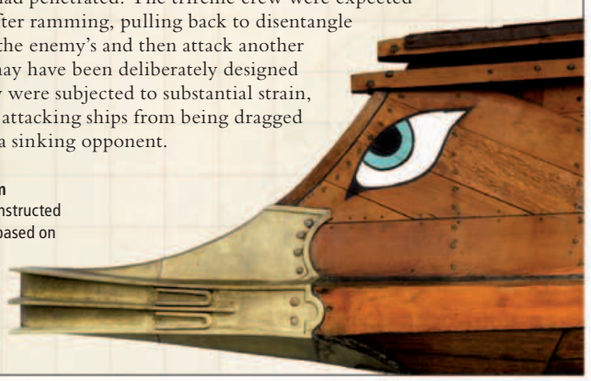
During the Ionian revolt of the early 5th century BCE, Persia laid siege to the city of Miletus by land and sea. The Greeks assembled a substantial fleet, mainly from the islands of Chios, Lesbos, and Samos. According to the historian Herodotus, their commander, Dionysius, berated the crews for their slackness, subjecting them to a tough training routine that led to mutinous discontent.

The Greeks sailed to confront the Persian fleet at Lade, Miletus's port. The Phoenicians drew up their ships in a defensive formation, while the triremes from Samos led the Greek attack, rowing toward their enemy in line ahead. The aim of the Greek tactics, carefully rehearsed by Dionysius, was to punch a hole in the Phoenician line by ramming. But the Samians, disaffected after their experience in training, had no stomach for the fight. Forty-nine of their 60 triremes never engaged the enemy, instead raising sails and heading for home. The 70 galleys from Lesbos followed suit. Vastly outnumbered, the remaining Greek triremes engaged the enemy, inflicting substantial losses, but were eventually overwhelmed and annihilated. This defeat condemned the Ionian revolt to failure.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

THE RAM OF A TRIREME

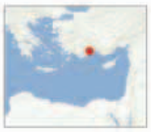
The bow of an Athenian trireme was equipped with a bronze-sheathed ram just below the waterline. Weighing around 440 lb (200 kg), its function was to smash the hull of an enemy vessel from the side. The ram was designed to avoid locking into the hull it had penetrated. The trireme crew were expected to reverse fast after ramming, pulling back to disentangle their ship from the enemy's and then attack another victim. Rams may have been deliberately designed to detach if they were subjected to substantial strain, thus preventing attacking ships from being dragged under water by a sinking opponent.



Bronze beaked ram
The ram on the reconstructed trireme *Olympias* is based on depictions in Greek art and on a well preserved example from the seabed near Haifa, Israel.

GRECO–PERSIAN WARS

TWIN BATTLES OF EURYMEDON



Date c.466 BCE
Forces Delian League: c.350 ships; Persians: c.350 ships
Losses Delian League: c.30 ships; Persians: c.240 ships

Location Eurymedon River, southern Turkey

The Athenian-led Delian League mounted a campaign to drive the Persians out of Asia Minor and establish firm control of the Aegean. After most coastal towns had fallen to the League, a fleet under the command of Cimon of Athens sought to bring the Persian fleet to battle. Cimon's naval force consisted of some 250 Athenian triremes plus 100 other ships supplied by allies. The Persians had a similar number of ships commanded by Tithrafstes, an illegitimate son of Xerxes. They were anchored in the mouth of the Eurymedon River, close to a force of Persian soldiers camped on the coast. According to the Greek historian Plutarch, the Persian fleet was expecting Phoenician reinforcements to arrive from Cyprus, so Cimon attacked as soon as he could. The Persians tried to row away but they were trapped and many of their ships were captured. The survivors joined the soldiers ashore. Landing with his sailors and marines, Cimon then won a second battle, attacking the Persian camp under cover of darkness. These "twin battles" were followed by another naval encounter, in which the Delian League pursued and destroyed the Phoenician reinforcements.

c.523–c.458 BCE

THEMISTOCLES

ATHENIAN POLITICIAN AND NAVAL COMMANDER

A prominent Athenian political leader, Themistocles takes credit for founding the city's naval power by persuading the popular assembly in 482 to spend the wealth from a newly discovered vein of silver on building a fleet of triremes. The following year he proposed the detailed measures adopted to organize the fleet to meet the Persian invasion, which were codified in the "Decree of Themistocles." During the key battles of Artemisium and Salamis he showed tactical ingenuity and political subtlety. He held together a fragile alliance with Sparta and his other Peloponnesian allies while discreetly exercising personal command of tactics and strategy. After the threat of Persian invasion had passed, Themistocles was involved in the rebuilding of Athens, which had been sacked by Xerxes, and in the development of Piraeus as the city's port. Always a controversial figure, he was later ostracized and expelled from Athens, ironically ending his life in the service of his old enemies, the Persians.

